

Media Depiction of Children in Indian Mainstream Media

Research Paper by: CRY Media Relations Interns (SCMC, Pune)

Period Covered: November 2024 - May 2025

Executive Summary

India has over 400 million children, but in the media, their stories rarely reflect that scale. Too often, children appear as statistics, victims, or policy footnotes rather than as full individuals with voices, struggles, and agency.

Globally, child-centric media has evolved to include youth voices in climate advocacy, education policy, and digital rights. Campaigns in countries like Finland, South Africa, and Brazil regularly quote school students and youth leaders. In India, however, children remain largely absent from the very stories that affect their futures.

This report brings together insights from six sub-reports and over 60 media stories (published between November 2024 and May 2025) to examine how Indian news platforms portray children across themes like education, health, nutrition, protection, digital safety, and climate impact. It asks a simple but urgent question: who gets to tell the story of childhood in India?

Key Highlights:

- Dominant themes include malnutrition, school dropouts, digital vulnerability, and legal safeguards.
 - Children are rarely quoted; most stories rely on government or expert sources.
 - English media dominates, and urban issues get more attention than rural or tribal concerns.
 - Less than 15% of stories offered solution-oriented or hopeful narratives.
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Methodology & Media Landscape

This report draws on a manual analysis of 65+ articles sourced from leading outlets like The Times of India, NDTV, The Hindu, Hindustan Times, and Navbharat Times. Each article was coded for tone, theme, voice, and geography.

Media Audit Snapshot:

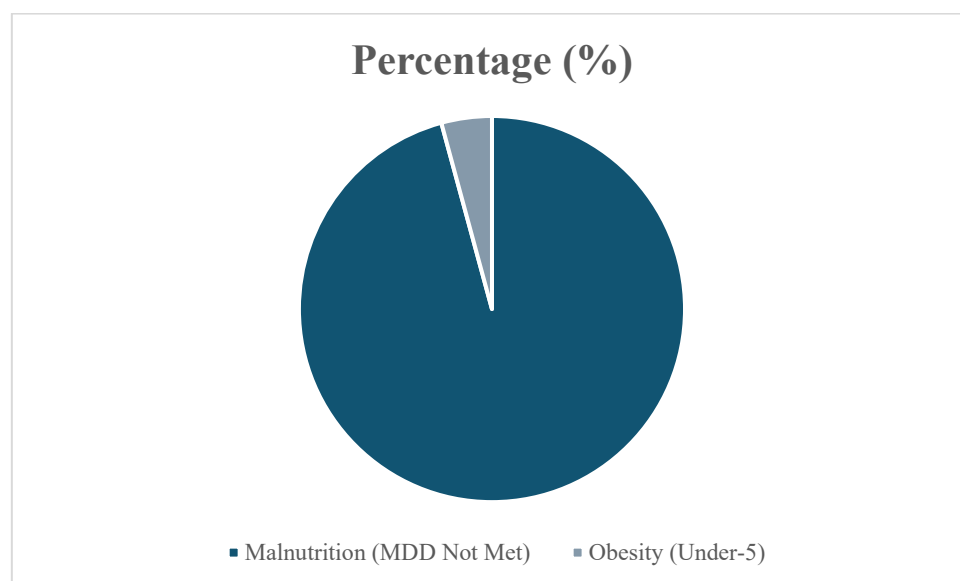
- **Language:** 60% English, 40% Hindi
- **Geography:** Coverage tilted toward Delhi, UP, Maharashtra
- **Theme Split:** Health (22), Education (21), Protection (10), Climate (12)

Voice analyses and narrative assessments were conducted. These reflections shaped this report's deeper observations. Hindi media tended to rely more on emotional appeals and local imagery, while English media stuck to institutional voices and press release-style summaries.

Health & Nutrition

Media stories about health often reported grim numbers—without human context:

- 77% of Indian children do not meet WHO's minimum dietary diversity
- Childhood obesity rose from 2.1% to 3.4% (NFHS-5)
- Only 18% of rural households have safe drinking water (Jal Jeevan Mission)



Narrative Gaps:

- No firsthand voices from children or caregivers
- Few stories explained “why” beyond raw data

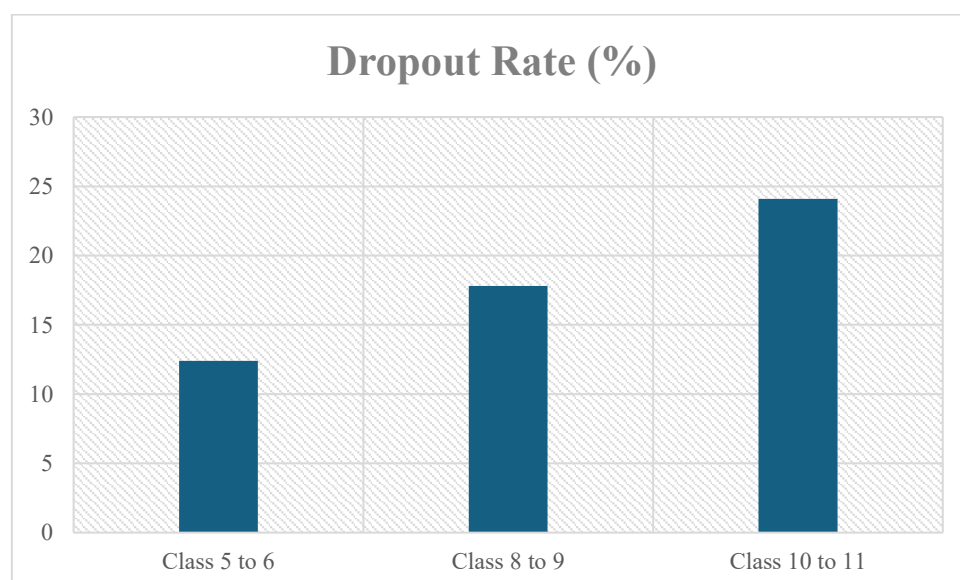
Even when large schemes like POSHAN or ICDS were mentioned, reporting failed to track local implementation. One story about a UP Anganwadi shutting due to heat left out what children ate that day or whether they were fed at all.

Regional coverage was skewed: drought-affected Bundelkhand, tribal Odisha, and remote Assam were almost invisible. Urban slums got passing mentions, often linked to malnutrition without community input.

Education

The education beat covered structural gaps, often without classroom realities:

- 1.1 million children out of school in 2024-25 (Hindustan Times)
- Major dropouts after Classes 5, 8, 10 (especially for girls)



What's Missing:

- Stories from teachers or students
- Regional inequalities (tribal schools, language access, special needs)

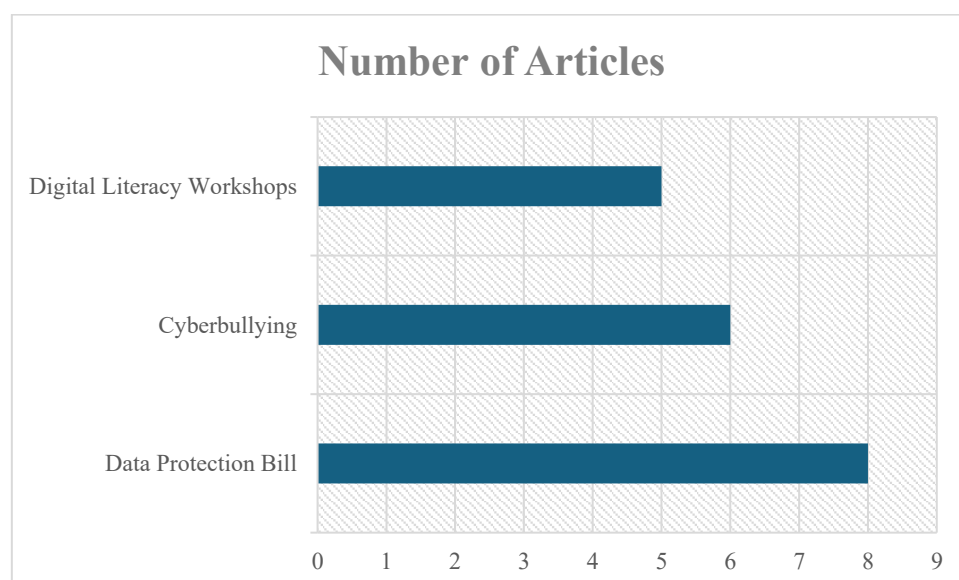
In one article, a Delhi High Court ruling on fee hikes for private schools was well-reported—but no parent or student was quoted. Reports on ASER 2024 noted improvement in basic numeracy and literacy but didn't include classroom scenes or teacher voices explaining how this shift happened.

The few mentions of NEP 2020 were high-level. There was no follow-up on how multilingualism or vocational integration was shaping real student journeys, especially in rural classrooms.

Digital Safety

Children's digital experiences gained visibility post-pandemic:

- New Data Protection Bill requires parental consent for under-18s online
- NGO-run digital literacy workshops in Rajasthan schools



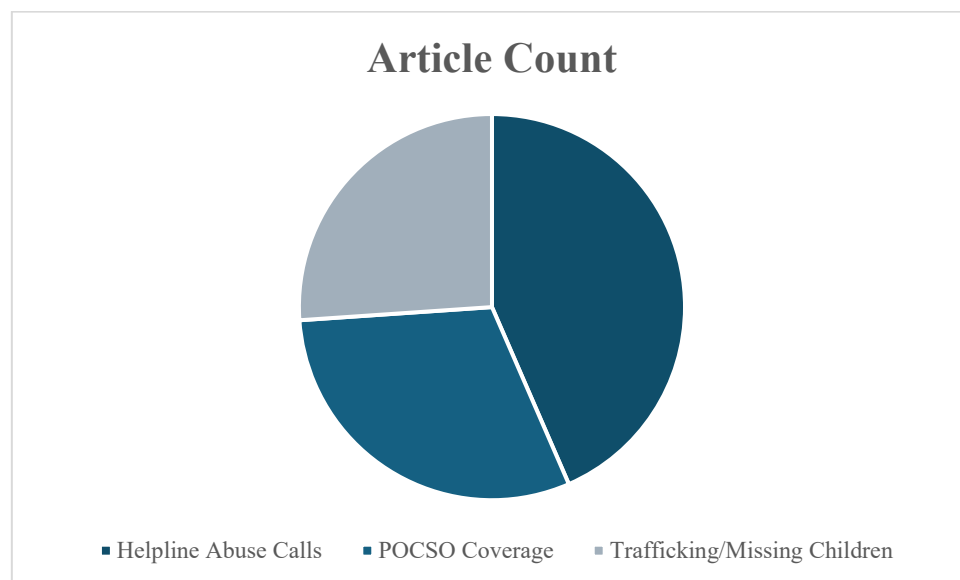
Most reports featured adult experts, with little to no youth testimony on screen time, cyberbullying, or app use.

For example, stories on the “Right to be Forgotten” law discussed implications for adolescents, but didn’t quote any digital natives. Meanwhile, coverage of YouTube addiction or gaming remained moralistic, without nuance or insight into how young people engage with technology.

Protection & Abuse

Violence coverage often leaned on shock value, police actions, or NCRB data:

- 50% of child helpline calls deal with abuse or counselling (TOI)
- Common terms used: “rescued”, “minor”, “POCSO case”



Missing:

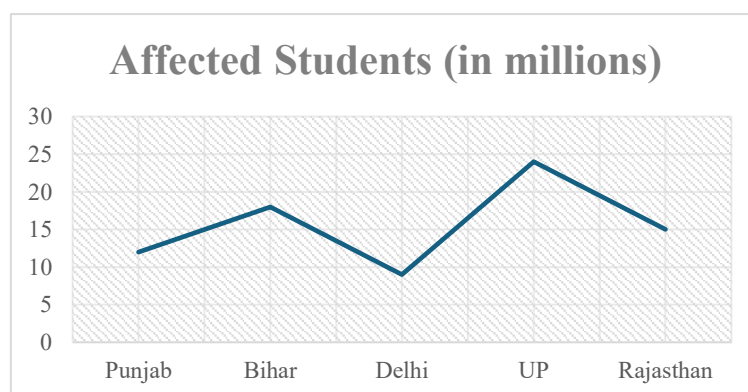
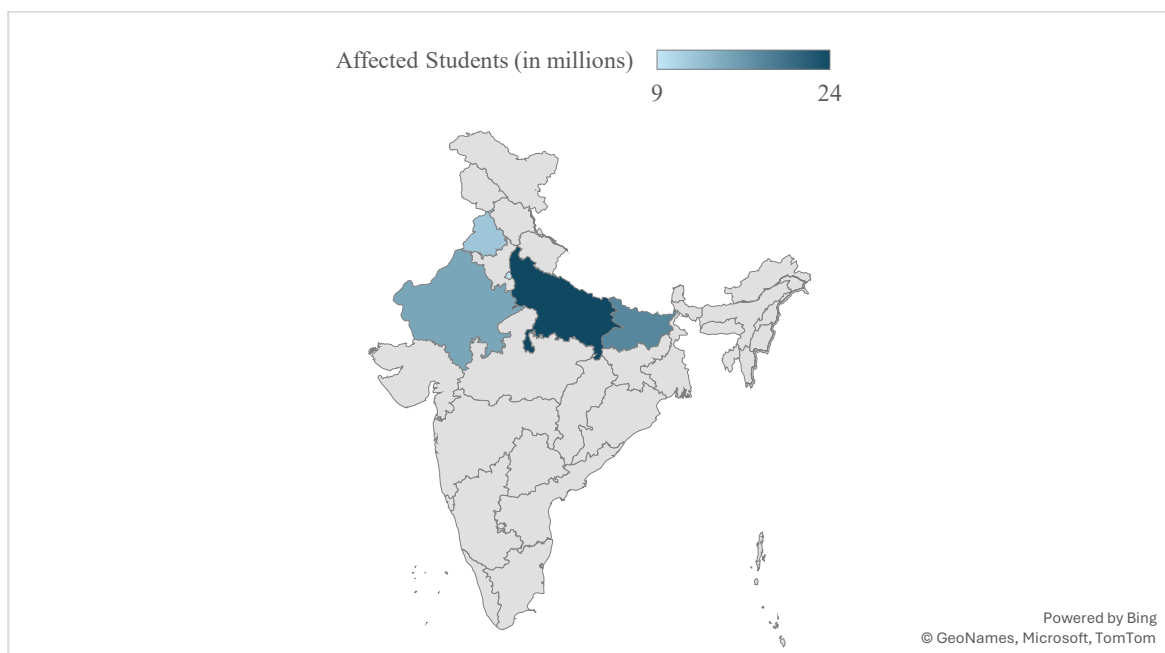
- Prevention-focused journalism
- Stories on mental health, support systems, or healing

The majority of articles on abuse framed children as passive victims. Few explained legal processes, follow-up support, or family dynamics. A more humane story might have explored what “healing” looks like or interviewed a social worker or helpline volunteer.

Climate & Children

Climate change coverage finally recognized child vulnerability:

- 118 million schoolchildren affected by heat-related school closures (April 2024)
- States like Punjab and Bihar shortened school days or switched to online modes



Yet few stories explored long-term impact on education, nutrition, or migration. Schools closing due to heat or flood is newsworthy—but what happens next? Are learning outcomes tracked? Were mid-day meals disrupted? Did dropout rates spike?

Only a couple of articles mentioned child-led climate advocacy. Rural students, despite bearing the brunt of disrupted schooling, were entirely absent from mainstream climate journalism.

Who Gets to Speak?

<2% of stories quoted children. Most featured bureaucrats, urban principals, and Delhi-based researchers.

Consistently underrepresented:

- Girls
- Children with disabilities
- Adivasi and Dalit youth

This silence reflects a deeper hierarchy where children are seen but not heard. Media often mirrors systems of exclusion: urban over rural, male over female, elite over marginal.

An interview with a 12-year-old climate striker or a drop-out who returned to school could transform a routine report into a story that sticks. Yet such voices remain untapped.

Global Ideas, Local Disconnect

Global frameworks were cited, but rarely localized:

- UNESCO's GEM report on school food standards
- WHO digital safety tools
- UNICEF's early childhood care principles

Example: A story quoting the UNESCO report on school meals did not consult any midday meal cook or student in India.

Indian media often borrows global language (“inclusive learning”, “universal access”) but fails to translate those ideas into Indian realities. Without grounded reporting, these frameworks feel like buzzwords.

Positive Trends

Not all media missed the mark. Bright spots included:

- NDTV’s explainer videos on heatwaves and child health
- Delhi’s school-led storytelling initiatives on climate
- Maharashtra’s “Aadharshila” program linking health + education

Recommendations from these examples:

- Involve youth reporters
- Fund multimedia projects in schools
- Cover resilience and reform -not just crisis

These stories stood out not only for what they covered but how. They humanized children as thinkers, creators, and citizens instead of treating them as recipients of services.

What Needs to Change

1. **Let Children Speak:** Quote children directly; invite them into the story
2. **Think Beyond Policy:** Focus on classrooms, playgrounds, homes
3. **Bring Visuals In:** Use data graphics, audio, video, and photography
4. **Cover With Context:** Show how caste, class, and gender shape access
5. **Cover More Geographies:** Tier-2 towns, rural belts, tribal schools

6. **Partner Smartly:** Work with child rights NGOs and youth collectives
 7. **Train Thoughtfully:** Run workshops on child-sensitive journalism
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Conclusion

Children are among the most discussed but least heard populations in Indian media. Their stories are framed by adults, spoken through data, or shaped by institutions.

This report urges a change. Journalists must move from *reporting on children* to *reporting with them*. That shift can transform media from a mirror into a megaphone.
